

Tertullian

Father of Latin Theology, Enemy of Compromise

A source-first historical biography

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1 A Master Cited but Never Canonized

The Catholic Church still prays in words it learned from Tertullian. When the *Catechism of the Catholic Church* introduces the Lord's Prayer, it reaches back to his treatise *On Prayer* for the description of the Our Father as "the summary of the whole Gospel" (CCC 2761, citing *De oratione* 1). The Latin theological vocabulary of the Trinity—one substance, three persons—enters Christian speech in his tract against Praxeas. His epigram that the blood of Christians is seed has been quoted for eighteen centuries. Yet Tertullian has no feast day, no cult, no shrine, and no title of Saint or Doctor. Jerome, writing about a hundred and seventy years after him, says he "lapsed to the doctrine of Montanus"; Augustine catalogued a small sect of *Tertullianistae* that survived in Carthage almost to his own day. When Pope Benedict XVI devoted a catechesis of his series on the Fathers to Tertullian on 30 May 2007, he presented him as both the founder of Latin Christian literature and a cautionary figure who ended outside the communion he had defended.

This biography asks what the sources actually establish about that double memory. Three questions govern it. First, what can be known—and what cannot be known—about the life of the man himself, once the late notices of Jerome and Augustine are weighed against what Tertullian says and fails to say about himself? Second, how did one converted rhetorician in Severan Carthage come to supply Latin Christianity with so much of its working language for God, Christ, church, sacrament, and conscience? Third, did he really leave the Church? The received story of a dated "Montanist secession" has been substantially reopened by modern scholarship, and this study preserves that disagreement rather than resolving it by fiat.

The method is that of the whole series: earliest controlled evidence first. Tertullian's own works are the primary witness, but they are advocacy and self-presentation, not a diary; the biographical notices of Eusebius, Jerome, and Augustine are received tradition written generations later; medieval and modern portraits are reception, not testimony. Each class is kept visible as the account proceeds, and the terminal appendix states the conventions, chronology, and limits that govern every page.

2 Carthage: A Church First Heard in a Courtroom

Tertullian's city was the second metropolis of the Latin West. Roman Carthage, rebuilt on the ruins of its Punic predecessor, was the seat of the proconsul of Africa, a grain port feeding Rome, and a famous school town whose rhetoricians and lawyers competed with those of the capital. Latin was the language of its public life, Greek the language of much of its learning, and beneath both lay Punic and Libyan populations whose presence in the churches can be glimpsed but not measured.

Christianity in Africa has no recorded founding. It first appears in the documentary record already Latin-speaking and already on trial. On 17 July 180, twelve Christians from the small town of Scilli stood before the proconsul Vigellius Saturninus: "When Praesens, for the second time, and Claudianus were the consuls, on the seventeenth day of July, at Carthage, there were set in the judgment-hall Speratus, Nartzalus, Cittinus, Donata, Secunda and Vestia" (*Acts of the Scillitan Martyrs* 1). The court record of their refusal and execution is the earliest securely dated Christian document from Africa, and among the earliest dated Christian texts in Latin. A generation later, in 203, the young matron Vibia Perpetua and the slave Felicity died in the amphitheatre of Carthage; the *Passion of Perpetua and Felicity* preserves Perpetua's prison diary, and Tertullian himself is the first author to cite her, invoking "the most heroic martyr Perpetua" and her vision of Paradise (*On the Soul* 55).

How the faith reached Africa—from Rome, from the East, by trade, or by several routes at once—is not recorded by any ancient source. Reconstructions from language, liturgy, or the African churches' later ties to Rome are modern inference, not evidence. The origin is simply unknown.

The church Tertullian joined was therefore a community whose formative literature consisted of interrogation transcripts and prison visions. Its self-understanding was forged under intermittent local persecution: not an empire-wide policy, but the standing possibility that a governor would apply the precedent against Christians who were denounced to him. Tertullian would later taunt the magistrates with the movement's growth—"we are but of yesterday, and we have filled every place among you—cities, islands, fortresses, towns, market-places, the very camp, tribes, companies, palace, senate, forum,—we have left nothing to you but the temples of your gods" (*Apology* 37)—and warn a persecuting proconsul about "so many thousands, of such a multitude of men and women, persons of every sex and every age and

every rank” in Carthage alone (*To Scapula* 5). These are an advocate’s totals, rhetorical rather than statistical; but they witness a community large enough to be visible, organized enough to be envied, and confident enough to argue with Rome in Rome’s own legal idiom. That idiom, and that confidence, are Tertullian’s signature.

3 The Evidence for a Life

3.1 What Tertullian says, and does not say, about himself

The manuscripts of his works transmit the full name Quintus Septimius Florens Tertullianus. Only once does the author name himself: the treatise *On the Veiling of Virgins* closes with a third-person subscription wishing peace to willing readers “as likewise to Septimius Tertullianus, whose this tractate is” (*On the Veiling of Virgins* 17). Everything else must be inferred from some thirty-one surviving Latin treatises, none of them autobiographical.

The inferences are nonetheless substantial. He wrote a supple, aggressive, learned Latin saturated with the techniques of the rhetorical schools, and he handled philosophical, medical, legal, and antiquarian material with the ease of an expensively educated man. He knew Greek well enough to compose in it: “this point has already received a fuller discussion from us in Greek,” he remarks of a baptismal question (*On Baptism* 15)—one of several notices of Greek works, all now lost. He was married; the two books *To His Wife* address her directly and ask that “after our departure,” she “renounce nuptials” (*To His Wife* 1.1). He was a convert who remembered being otherwise: he exhorts “that repentance, O sinner, like myself,” be embraced “as a shipwrecked man the protection of some plank” (*On Repentance* 4), and his works assume intimate former acquaintance with the games, the theatre, and pagan civic religion. Most strikingly, he twice speaks of himself as one of the laity. Arguing that in extremity every Christian may baptize and offer, he asks, “Are not even we laics priests? . . . where three are, a church is, albeit they be laics” (*On Exhortation to Chastity* 7); and in *On Monogamy* he mocks how “we,” the laity, exalt ourselves against the clergy when it suits us (*On Monogamy* 12).

3.2 The received portrait: Jerome and Eusebius

The earliest connected biography is a paragraph written about 392–393. Jerome of Stridon, in his catalogue *On Illustrious Men*, makes Tertullian “the presbyter, now regarded as chief of the Latin writers,” a Carthaginian, “the son of a proconsul or centurion, a man of keen and vigorous character”; he flourished under Severus and Caracalla; he “was presbyter of the church until middle life, afterwards driven by the envy and abuse of the clergy of the Roman church, he lapsed to the doctrine of Montanus”; in old age he wrote many works now lost, and “he is said to have lived to a decrepit old age” (*On Illustrious Men* 53). Jerome also preserves the most famous item of ancient reception: an old man of Concordia who had known Cyprian’s secretary told him that Cyprian read Tertullian daily and would ask for the book with the words “Give me the master” (*Da magistrum*) (ibid.).

Almost a century before Jerome, Eusebius of Caesarea had cited the *Apology*—which he knew in a Greek translation—and introduced its author as “a man well versed in the laws of the Romans, and in other respects of high repute, and one of those especially distinguished in Rome” (*Church History* 2.2.4; cf. 5.5, where Tertullian is “a trustworthy witness”). Eusebius thus places Tertullian, at least by reputation, in a Roman and legal milieu.

3.3 The modern audit of the portrait

Twentieth-century scholarship subjected this portrait to a severe audit, most influentially Timothy Barnes’s *Tertullian: A Historical and Literary Study* (1971). Barnes argued that nearly every biographical detail not found in Tertullian’s own works dissolves on inspection: “Tertullian’s father was not a centurion; there never was a *centurio proconsularis*”—the office rests on a corrupted text of Jerome; the presbyterate contradicts Tertullian’s own lay self-description; the identification of the Christian writer with the jurist Tertullianus excerpted in the *Digest* is unfounded; Eusebius’s Roman legal expert is an inference from the *Apology*’s forensic manner; and the tale that envy of the Roman clergy drove him to Montanism explains nothing in the African evidence. On Barnes’s minimal reconstruction, Tertullian was a lay, married, classically educated Carthaginian who wrote intensively between about 196 and 212 and died not long afterwards. Reviewers accepted much of the demolition while doubting the compression: W. H. C. Frend, among others, held that Jerome “is unlikely to have been completely mistaken” on every point and that the traditional longer

life—birth around 155–160, death, on Jerome’s report of great old age, perhaps as late as the 220s—could not be excluded (Frend 1974). No consensus has replaced the ranges: birth somewhere in c. 155–170, death after 212 at an unknown date.

Every element of the customary summary “born c. 155, son of a centurion, lawyer in Rome, priest of Carthage, died c. 220” is either a late report, a disputed reading, or a modern inference. This study therefore treats only the self-witness and the dated works as controlling, and reports the rest as tradition under review.

4 The Convert as Advocate

Tertullian’s datable literary career opens with a burst of apologetic. The twin works *To the Nations* and the *Apology* are generally placed in 197 on the basis of their references to the civil wars that brought Septimius Severus—himself an African—to sole power; the dating is a scholarly reconstruction from internal allusions, not an ancient statement, but it is broadly accepted. What is certain is their strategy. Instead of pleading for pity, Tertullian indicts the legal process itself: Christians are punished for a name, under a procedure that inverts every Roman norm, on charges—incest, infanticide, disloyalty—that no court ever bothers to prove. Torture, used on others to compel confession, is used on Christians to compel denial. The argument is that of a trained forensic mind enjoying the absurdity of its opponents’ case.

Within the indictment stands a portrait of the church from inside, the first in Latin. “We are a body knit together as such by a common religious profession, by unity of discipline, and by the bond of a common hope,” he writes; the community’s fund is “piety’s deposit fund,” spent not on banquets but “to support and bury poor people, to supply the wants of boys and girls destitute of means and parents, and of old persons confined now to the house,” and on the shipwrecked, and on those in the mines and prisons for the Name; and the pagans themselves testify, “See, they say, how they love one another” (*Apology* 39). Two of his sentences became permanent Christian property: the observation, against the persecutors, that “the oftener we are mown down by you, the more in number we grow; the blood of Christians is seed” (*Apology* 50), and the exclamation “O noble testimony of the soul by nature Christian!”—the soul that, startled, cries out to the one God it pretends not to know (*Apology* 17).

The *Apology* is also the first Latin Christian book with a traceable international readership: Eusebius cites it repeatedly through a Greek translation (*Church History* 2.2.4)—the direction of translation now reversed, Greek Christianity reading an African Latin.

Fifteen years later the advocate returned to the same brief in miniature. *To Scapula*, an open letter to the proconsul Scapula who had resumed executions, is datable with unusual precision: it mentions a portentous darkening of the sun “in the metropolis of Utica” (*To Scapula* 3), commonly identified with the eclipse visible in Africa on 14 August 212. The letter contains the most remarkable sentence of early Christian political thought: “it is a fundamental human right, a privilege of nature, that every man should worship according to his own convictions” (*To Scapula* 2). The claim is not modern religious liberalism—Tertullian is arguing that coerced worship is worthless to any god—but no earlier writer is known to have stated the principle so baldly, and it is regularly invoked in modern discussions of religious freedom. After *To Scapula*, nothing Tertullian wrote can be securely dated; the advocate’s last dated word is a threat wrapped in a plea for his persecutors’ own good.

5 A Working Church: Baptism, Prayer, Penance, Marriage

Because Tertullian wrote for catechumens, spouses, and penitents as well as against enemies, his corpus is an unmatched window on what a Latin church around the year 200 actually did. The evidence must be read as advocacy—he is always urging a practice, rarely just describing one—but the practices themselves are not invented.

On Baptism, the earliest surviving treatise on any sacrament, defends the humble efficacy of water against a female teacher who denied it. “We, little fishes, after the example of our *Ichthys* Jesus Christ, are born in water,” he begins—the Greek acrostic “fish” standing for Christ—“nor have we safety in any other way than by permanently abiding in water” (*On Baptism* 1). The treatise attests a developed rite—renunciation, immersion, anointing—and, in passing, an episode of church discipline elsewhere: the presbyter in Asia who composed the apocryphal *Acts of Paul*, “after being convicted, and confessing that he had done it from love of Paul, was removed from his office” (*On*

Baptism 17), an early datum for how the church policed writings about the apostles. *On Prayer* expounds the Our Father for catechumens as a compression of the entire Gospel—the characterization the Catholic Church still quotes.

On Repentance shows the second-century penitential system mid-development. Baptism is the great forgiveness; for grave sin afterwards, God “in the vestibule has stationed the second repentance for opening to such as knock: but now once for all, because now for the second time; but never more” (*On Repentance* 7). That second chance takes bodily form in *exomologesis*, the public discipline in which the sinner is commanded “to lie in sackcloth and ashes, to cover his body in mourning,” and “to bow before the feet of the presbyters” (*On Repentance* 9). The whole later history of the sacrament of penance—and Tertullian’s own later fury at its relaxation—starts from this once-only public rigor.

The Chaplet preserves the classic early list of practices held on custom and tradition rather than on a scriptural text: the solemn renunciation of “the devil, and his pomp, and his angels” before baptism, the threefold immersion, the taste of milk and honey for the newly baptized, and two habits of enormous later history—“we make offerings for the dead as birthday honours,” that is, the Eucharist offered on the anniversary of a death, and the constant signing of the cross: “At every forward step and movement, at every going in and out... in all the ordinary actions of daily life, we trace upon the forehead the sign” (*The Chaplet* 3). Tertullian cites these precisely because they are unwritten, arguing that observed tradition can bind; the passage remains a locus classicus in Catholic accounts of tradition.

The household had its theology too. The second book *To His Wife* closes with the most quoted early Christian praise of marriage: “What kind of yoke is that of two believers, (partakers) of one hope, one desire, one discipline, one and the same service?... truly two in one flesh. Where the flesh is one, one is the spirit too”; they pray and fast together, and “When Christ sees and hears, He joys” (*To His Wife* 2.8). The same pen that could scorch could also bless; the blessing, characteristically, is for a marriage inside the discipline of the church, contracted before it and confirmed by its oblation.

6 Drawing the Boundary: Prescription and Polemic

The same forensic instinct that indicted the persecutors organized Tertullian’s war on heresy. His master-stroke, the *Prescription Against Heretics*, transfers to theology the Roman litigator’s *praescriptio*—a plea that defeats an opponent’s case before its merits are argued. Heretics appeal to Scripture; Tertullian answers that the Scriptures are the property of the churches that received them from the apostles, so that outsiders have no standing to argue from them at all. The rule of faith, publicly taught in the apostolic churches, settles in advance what the documents mean. Anyone who doubts where those churches are may “run over the apostolic churches, in which the very thrones of the apostles are still pre-eminent in their places”—Corinth, Philippi, Ephesus; and for an African, Rome is nearest: “How happy is its church, on which apostles poured forth all their doctrine along with their blood! where Peter endures a passion like his Lord’s! where Paul wins his crown in a death like John’s” (*Prescription* 36)—an early and independent Latin witness to the Roman deaths of Peter and Paul. The treatise also fixed his most famous antithesis: “What indeed has Athens to do with Jerusalem? What concord is there between the Academy and the Church?” (*Prescription* 7). The sentence is a standing temptation to misquotation: its author was soaked in the philosophy he here forswears, used Stoic materials throughout his theology, and elsewhere calls the philosophers to witness. It is a rule against mixing authorities, not a ban on thought.

The prescription in hand, Tertullian still argued the merits, at enormous length, against named opponents: Hermogenes the painter, the Valentinian schools, the philosophical psychologies answered in *On the Soul*, and above all Marcion of Pontus, whose severed god of pure goodness and mutilated Scriptures he pursued through five books. *Against Marcion* is also the anchor of his chronology. Its preface confesses a publishing history: a hurried first edition, then a fuller one lost “by the fraud of a person who was then a brother, but became afterwards an apostate,” who circulated a faulty copy, and now a third, definitive edition (*Against Marcion* 1.1). And in its first book he dates Marcion’s novelty “to the fifteenth of the Emperor Severus” (*Against Marcion* 1.15)—the fifteenth year of Septimius Severus, 207/208, the one absolute date Tertullian ever gives for his own time of writing.

Marcion, Hermogenes, Praxeas, and the Valentinians survive almost entirely in the words of their enemies. Tertullian’s reports are controlled polemic: modern scholarship uses them cautiously and does not treat his reconstruction of any opponent as neutral description. This study cites them for Tertullian’s side of the argument only.

For Latin Christianity the consequences were permanent. The prescription argument—Scripture read within the apostolic churches under the rule of faith—became a standing instrument of Catholic controversy long after its author’s own standing had become an embarrassment to those who used it.

7 Coining the Latin of God: Trinity, Christ, Soul, Flesh

Tertullian’s largest single legacy is linguistic. Latin Christianity needed words for what Greek theology was still struggling to say, and Tertullian, a century and a quarter before Nicaea, minted much of the durable stock.

The occasion was a Roman quarrel. A certain Praxeas—otherwise unknown, and possibly a nickname—taught that the Father himself became incarnate and suffered, collapsing Father and Son into a single actor. The same man, says Tertullian, had earlier persuaded a bishop of Rome to withdraw letters recognizing the new prophecy in Asia; thus “Praxeas did a twofold service for the devil at Rome: he drove away prophecy, and he brought in heresy; he put to flight the Paraclete, and he crucified the Father” (*Against Praxeas* 1). The reply, *Against Praxeas*, sets out the vocabulary that stuck: God is one substance in three—“three, however, not in condition, but in degree; not in substance, but in form; not in power, but in aspect; yet of one substance, and of one condition, and of one power” (*Against Praxeas* 2). Here for the first time in surviving Christian literature the word *trinitas* does systematic work, together with *substantia* for the one Godhead and *persona* for the three. The same treatise anticipates Chalcedon by two and a half centuries on the person of Christ: “we see plainly the twofold state, which is not confounded, but conjoined in One Person—Jesus, God and Man,” each substance preserving its own properties (*Against Praxeas* 27).

Anticipation is not identity. Tertullian’s terms were forged in a pre-conciliar semantic world: his “substance” carries Stoic overtones of body, his Son proceeds from the Father for creation, and fourth-century standards of co-eternity should not be read back into him. The Church later received his vocabulary while correcting parts of his conceptual scaffolding. The claim made here is lexical and structural, not that Tertullian taught Nicene and Chalcedonian doctrine *avant la lettre*.

The same Stoic realism shaped his psychology and his hope. In *On the Soul* he argued that the soul is real precisely because, in his physics, it is corporeal in its own fashion—a position Augustine would later single out for correction, while pillaging the treatise for everything else. The soul, for Tertullian, is not saved out of the body but with it. *On the Flesh of Christ* defends the full, unglamorous reality of Christ’s human birth against docetic refinement, and *On the Resurrection of the Flesh* builds the case that salvation runs through the body, in a deliberately sacramental key: “The flesh, indeed, is washed, in order that the soul may be cleansed; the flesh is anointed, that the soul may be consecrated” (*On the Resurrection of the Flesh* 8). No ancient writer tied Christianity more tightly to matter: water, oil, milk, bread, blood, flesh. The theologian of the world’s contempt was, doctrinally, the great anti-spiritualizer.

8 The New Prophecy and the Hardening of Discipline

8.1 A movement from Phrygia

In the later second century a prophetic revival arose in the interior of Asia Minor. Eusebius’s dossier of hostile witnesses locates its origin with Montanus, a recent convert who began to prophesy in ecstasy in “a certain village called Ardabau in that part of Mysia, which borders upon Phrygia” (*Church History* 5.16.7); with him stood the prophetesses Prisca (Priscilla) and Maximilla. Its adherents called it the New Prophecy; its enemies, the Phrygian heresy. The movement claimed that the Paraclete promised in John’s Gospel was speaking through its prophets, not to alter the faith but to tighten the discipline: more fasting, no flight in persecution, no remarriage, no pardon in this life for the gravest sins. Asian synods condemned it; at Rome, on Tertullian’s own testimony, a bishop first issued letters of peace to the churches of the New Prophecy and then, at Praxeas’s urging, recalled them (*Against Praxeas* 1).

8.2 Tertullian’s adherence

When and how the New Prophecy reached Carthage is unrecorded. From roughly the period of *Against Marcion* (207/208) onward, Tertullian’s works increasingly cite the Paraclete’s oracles and defend the movement by name, and he

divides Christians into the “spiritual,” who receive the new discipline, and the *psychici*—“animal” or “carnally-minded” folk—who do not. He is admirably candid about what was and was not at stake: the New Prophecies are rejected, he protests, “not that Montanus and Priscilla and Maximilla preach another God, nor that they disjoin Jesus Christ, . . . but that they plainly teach more frequent fasting than marrying” (*On Fasting* 1). The epigram cut both ways in *On Monogamy*: “Heretics do away with marriages; Psychics accumulate them. The former marry not even once; the latter not only once” (*On Monogamy* 1). The disputes he now prosecuted—may a widower remarry, may a Christian flee persecution, must virgins be veiled, how often must one fast—were disputes of discipline among people who recited the same creed, and Tertullian himself theorized exactly that distinction: “the rule of faith, indeed, is altogether one, alone immovable and irreformable,” while “the other succeeding points of discipline and conversation admit the novelty of correction”—the Paraclete being, on his account, the appointed corrector (*On the Veiling of Virgins* 1).

His most bitter late work turned the point of discipline into a point of authority. *On Modesty* opens in outrage at a new leniency: “I hear that there has even been an edict set forth, and a peremptory one too. The *Pontifex Maximus*—that is, the bishop of bishops—issues an edict: ‘I remit, to such as have discharged (the requirements of) repentance, the sins both of adultery and of fornication’” (*On Modesty* 1). The mocking titles have traditionally been referred to Callistus of Rome; a substantial body of modern scholarship refers the edict instead to an African bishop; the identification is unresolved, and this study leaves it so. What the treatise shows beyond doubt is the distance travelled by its author: the man who had celebrated the “second repentance” now denies that the church should absolve adultery at all, and confesses the reversal openly—“this too, therefore, shall be a count in my indictment against the Psychics; against the fellowship of sentiment also which I myself formerly maintained with them” (*On Modesty* 1).

Yet the same late works picture him inside a worshipping congregation, not a conventicle of the pure. *On the Soul* describes, in the present tense, “a sister whose lot it has been to be favoured with sundry gifts of revelation, which she experiences in the Spirit by ecstatic vision amidst the sacred rites of the Lord’s day in the church”; only “after the people are dismissed at the conclusion of the sacred services” does she report what she has seen, and her visions are examined (*On the Soul* 9). Prophecy here operates within the liturgy, under scrutiny, alongside psalms, readings, and petitions. Whatever Tertullian had joined, it still looked, from the inside, like church.

9 Did Tertullian Leave the Church?

9.1 The ancient answers

The ancient tradition is unanimous that he fell, and vague about what falling meant. Jerome says he “was presbyter of the church until middle life, afterwards driven by the envy and abuse of the clergy of the Roman church, he lapsed to the doctrine of Montanus,” and composed volumes “directly against the church” (*On Illustrious Men* 53). Augustine, cataloguing heresies in 428, goes further: Tertullian became a heretic not for his corporeal notion of soul and God but because, joining the Cataphrygians whom he had once opposed, he condemned second marriage as unchastity contrary to apostolic teaching, and then split even from them to found congregations of his own; the *Tertullianistae* dwindled until, in Augustine’s own day, the last few in Carthage returned to the Catholic Church and surrendered their basilica (*On Heresies* 86). The anonymous *Praedestinatus* (c. 430s), a compilation of slight independent value, adds a Tertullianist minister active in Rome under the usurper Maximus (383–388) and a basilica in Carthage where Tertullian’s people gathered until Bishop Aurelius; its embellishments mainly show how little the fifth century still knew.

9.2 What the contemporary record shows—and omits

Tertullian’s own works, our only contemporary evidence, yield a striking double result. On the one hand, real estrangement: he writes of the “carnally-minded” majority with contempt, and in *Against Praxeas* 1 he says plainly, “we indeed, on our part, subsequently withdrew from the carnally-minded on our acknowledgment and maintenance of the Paraclete.” On the other hand, a total absence of the apparatus of schism. Nowhere does he claim a rival bishop, altar, or ordination; nowhere does he unchurch the bishops whose discipline he derides; his New Prophecy circle appears, in *On the Soul* 9, worshipping within the common Sunday liturgy. No ancient source records an excommunication, a synodal condemnation of Tertullian, or a formal act by which he left or was expelled; even Jerome’s “lapse” is doctrinal, not juridical.

9.3 The modern reassessment

On this evidential base, twentieth- and twenty-first-century scholarship substantially rebuilt the question. Douglas Powell's study of the Tertullianists concluded that the African New Prophecy of Tertullian's lifetime shows no organizational break: "Nowhere does he refer to Montanist bishops, nowhere does he deny that the African bishops were genuinely bishops, nowhere does he say that the *ecclesia numerus episcoporum* is no true Church" (Powell 1975). On this reading the Carthaginian adherents of the Paraclete remained for decades a rigorist fellowship within the Catholic community—an *ecclesiola in ecclesia*—and Augustine's neat sequence (Montanist, then founder of his own sect) is a fifth-century construction from the mere existence of a group later called by his name. Timothy Barnes read the *Tertullianistae* as simply the African branch of the Montanists, carrying the local teacher's name rather than his personal foundation; David Rankin's full-length study argued that Tertullian probably never left the Catholic church at all, belonging instead to a New Prophecy group within it and pressing his campaign against slackness from inside (Rankin 1995); William Tabbernee has suggested the later group may have been little more than a circle formed around Tertullian's memory and writings. The older confident narrative—Chapman's 1912 Catholic Encyclopedia article could still write that Tertullian "seems to have definitively separated from the Church about 211"—no longer commands assent, for the date rests on nothing.

The reassessment is itself a set of named modern reconstructions, not a new fact. The withdrawal sentence of *Against Praxeas* 1 is real; the New Prophecy had been refused communion in Asia and, after the recalled letters, at Rome; and *On Modesty* treats the bishops' penitential authority with open scorn. A rupture of some kind—of fellowship, of sympathy, possibly eventually of communion—is not in doubt; its formal, institutional character is. This study therefore reports Tertullian's status at death as unresolved, with the weight of current scholarship against a formal personal schism.

10 Old Age, Silence, and the End

After *To Scapula* in 212, the record goes quiet. None of the surviving works can be securely dated later, though several of the disciplinary treatises may belong to the following years. Jerome reports that Tertullian went on writing—six books *On Ecstasy* and a seventh against the anti-Montanist writer Apollonius, all lost—and that "he is said to have lived to a decrepit old age" (*On Illustrious Men* 53). Even Jerome marks this with "he is said": it is hearsay at a hundred and seventy years' distance.

Nothing else survives. No ancient writer records the year, place, cause, or circumstances of Tertullian's death; none records his burial; no grave, relic, shrine, or commemoration is attested in any period; no source reports either a deathbed reconciliation or a final defiance. The date "c. 220" or "c. 225" found in reference works is a convention that splices the end of the datable works (212) with Jerome's old-age report; Barnes's compressed alternative—a death not long after 212, perhaps in his forties—remains equally possible. The silence should be stated as what it is. A man whose sentences the Latin church would quote forever disappears from history without a recorded end.

The one thread that runs past his death is the group bearing his name. Augustine's notice is contemporary witness for its own time: the *Tertullianistae* had dwindled for generations, and their "very few" remaining members in Carthage came over to the Catholic Church, surrendering their basilica, within Augustine's memory; the related notice in the *Praedestinatus* places the surrender under Bishop Aurelius of Carthage, Augustine's contemporary (*On Heresies* 86; *Praedestinatus* 86). What the group had been—a schismatic church descending from Tertullian's own act, the African Montanist community renamed, or a fellowship keeping the master's books and memory—is precisely what the sources do not say. Its end, at least, is documented: the last African rigorists walked back into the basilica of the bishops their founder had mocked, and handed over the keys.

11 Reception: The Master Nobody Canonized

11.1 Ancient and late-antique judgment

The shape of Tertullian's reception was fixed early: indispensable and suspect, in that order. Cyprian, bishop of Carthage within a generation of him, is reported never to have passed a day without reading him, asking his secretary,

“Give me the master” (Jerome, *On Illustrious Men* 53)—and Cyprian’s surviving treatises rework Tertullian’s themes without naming him. Lactantius, the first to survey Latin Christian letters, granted that Tertullian “was skilled in literature of every kind” but complained that “in eloquence he had little readiness, and was not sufficiently polished, and very obscure” (*Divine Institutes* 5.1)—a stylist’s verdict on a style that the following centuries nevertheless kept quoting. Eusebius cited the *Apology* with respect; Jerome made him “chief of the Latin writers” after none; Augustine used *On the Soul* and the moral treatises even while cataloguing their author among the heretics. Vincent of Lérins gave the ambivalence its classical form: “who more learned than he, who more versed in knowledge whether divine or human?”—and yet, adopting Hilary’s judgment that “by his subsequent error he detracted from the authority of his approved writings,” Vincent concluded that Tertullian, like Origen among the Greeks, “was a great trial in the Church” (*Commonitorium* 18). By the sixth century the so-called Gelasian Decree, a Roman index of receivable and non-receivable books, simply listed the works of Tertullian among the *apocrypha*, between the history of Eusebius and the works of Lactantius—not condemned for a doctrine, but not to be received as authoritative either (*Decretum Gelasianum*, list of apocrypha).

The Middle Ages accordingly nearly lost him. Outside the *Apology*, which travelled well, his works survived in a handful of precarious collections; a substantial part of the corpus depends on single manuscripts or on early printed editions of manuscripts since destroyed. What survived sufficed for the Renaissance and for every century since to rediscover him with a start.

11.2 Not a saint, and yet a Father

Tertullian was never canonized and has no feast; no cult, calendar entry, or liturgical commemoration of him, ancient or modern, was located in the research for this study (a bounded negative search; see the appendix). He is likewise no Doctor of the Church—a title requiring sanctity as well as eminent doctrine. Yet he is universally treated as a Church Father in the broad sense: the patristic manuals, the critical editions of the Fathers, and the Church’s own documents handle him as a primary witness to ancient faith and practice. The *Catechism of the Catholic Church* quotes his *On Prayer* for the Lord’s Prayer as “the summary of the whole Gospel” (CCC 2761); Benedict XVI gave him an entire general audience in his patristic catecheses (30 May 2007), presenting the man who began Christian Latin literature and gave the Trinity its Latin grammar, and who yet, by increasing rigor and the demand for perfection, ended separated from the common life of the Church—for Benedict, a standing lesson that theological brilliance without the humility to remain with the Church consumes itself. Selective citation, it should be stressed, is reception of particular formulations, not rehabilitation of the whole corpus or a judgment on the man’s end.

11.3 The contested pages

An honest account keeps the pages later ages winced at. The treatise *On the Apparel of Women* addresses its readers, on the strength of Eve’s primacy in the Fall, in the sentence for which Tertullian is now most often indicted: “You are the devil’s gateway: you are the unsealer of that (forbidden) tree: you are the first deserter of the divine law” (*On the Apparel of Women* 1.1). It stands in a genre of moral invective against luxury, in a corpus that also praises the shared discipleship of husband and wife (*To His Wife* 2.8), honors Perpetua as “the most heroic martyr” (*On the Soul* 55), and reports women exercising recognized prophetic gifts in the liturgy (*On the Soul* 9); but the sentence is his, the theology of blame in it is his, and no genre plea dissolves it. Similarly, the closing chapter of *The Shows* savors the damnation of the persecutors, philosophers, and actors as the best spectacle of all—“What there excites my admiration? What my derision? Which sight gives me joy?” (*The Shows* 30)—a page that has served every critic of Christian vindictiveness from the Enlightenment onward. The rigorist imagination that made Tertullian a matchless witness against comfortable Christianity is the same one that could not wait for mercy. Both facts belong to his legacy.

11.4 The modern rebalancing

Modern scholarship, meanwhile, quietly returned him to the Church’s history. Where the nineteenth century wrote confidently of “Tertullian the Montanist,” the current literature writes of a Catholic controversialist of rigorist temper whose New Prophecy allegiance need not have carried him out of communion, whose “sect” may be an artifact of fifth-century cataloguing, and whose lay voice—if lay he was—is among the most important we possess for ante-Nicene

Christianity. The paradox Vincent named remains: the Latin Church's first master theologian is the one it can quote but not celebrate.

12 Conclusion: Fierce Fidelity

Strip away the unverifiable portrait—the centurion's son, the Roman jurist, the priest—and what remains is in some ways more impressive: a married layman of Carthage who, in about sixteen documented years, created Christian Latin literature almost single-handedly. He gave the persecuted church a legal defense it could be proud of; he gave the Latin language its working terms for the Trinity and the person of Christ; he described, first and best, the baptisms, prayers, penances, offerings, and marriages of an ancient Christian community; he built the argument from apostolic tradition that his Catholic successors would use for centuries; and he stamped on Western Christianity a conviction it has never lost, that faith is a discipline of the body or it is nothing.

The same evidence shows what the fierceness cost. Tertullian's certainty that the Spirit demanded ever more—more fasting, no remarriage, no pardon for the flesh's gravest failures, no flight from the persecutor—set him against the bishops' pastoral practice and, in his own words, withdrew him from the “carnally-minded.” Whether that withdrawal ever became formal schism, the contemporary record does not say, and the late reports that say it do not inspire confidence; the modern reassessment has restored real uncertainty where certainty of his apostasy once reigned. What is certain is the judgment of the church that kept reading him: master and warning at once, quoted by the Catechism and absent from the calendar.

Perhaps the most exact epitaph is the one his own theology supplies. He taught that the flesh is the hinge of salvation—that God saves not disembodied spirits but patient, humiliated, mortal bodies. Patience with bodies, his own included, was the one discipline he could not keep; he even wrote *Of Patience* confessing himself “most miserable, ever sick with the heats of impatience,” like the invalid who praises the health he lacks (*Of Patience* 1). The Church received the doctrine and declined the temper, which is, on the evidence of this study, roughly what he deserved and perhaps what he expected. His last securely dated sentence pleaded for his persecutors' souls; his tradition ends with his followers returning quietly to the bishops' communion. Between those two facts the unresolved question of Tertullian—inside or outside—keeps its permanent, instructive tension.

A Scope, Chronology, and Evidence

A.1 Identity, names, and range

Subject: Tertullian of Carthage, transmitted in the manuscripts as Quintus Septimius Florens Tertullianus and self-named once as “Septimius Tertullianus” (*On the Veiling of Virgins* 17). Whole-life range used in this study: born c. 155–170 (no ancient evidence; modern estimate from the career), documented literary activity c. 196/197–212, died after 212 at an unknown date; the customary “c. 220/225” rests on Jerome's old-age report and is treated as convention, not fact. Principal place: Carthage, capital of Roman Africa Proconsularis (near modern Tunis). A period of residence in Rome is suggested by Eusebius's description but is not established by Tertullian's own works and is treated as unverified.

A.2 Reader, question, and thesis boundary

Written for a serious general reader, student, or researcher who wants one coherent, evidence-controlled life. The governing questions are stated in the opening section. The thesis—that Tertullian's achievement and his estrangement flow from one rigorist temperament, and that his formal ecclesiastical fate is unresolved—is a historical synthesis. This study does not decide his eternal state, adjudicate the Callistus/African-bishop identification, reconstruct his opponents independently, settle New Prophecy institutional history, or issue any theological or canonical judgment; it claims no ecclesiastical review or approval.

A.3 Corpus and citation conventions

About thirty-one Latin treatises are accepted as authentic; this study cites them by their conventional English titles and the chapter numbers of the Ante-Nicene Fathers translation (vols. 3–4, Buffalo 1885), whose wording is used for all quotations of Tertullian and of most other ancient authors; quotations were checked against the online transcriptions identified in the References on 2026-07-24. Works are dated only where stated in the text; relative chronology of the undated works is disputed and no work-by-work chronology is asserted. Spurious and doubtful works (e.g., *Against All Heresies*) are not used. Lost works (the Greek treatises, *On Ecstasy*) are cited only as reported by Tertullian or Jerome.

A.4 Evidence classes

Class	Meaning
A	Tertullian’s own works: contemporary, but advocacy and self-presentation; each claim limited by genre, occasion, and polemical purpose.
N	Contemporary or near-contemporary external witness (Acts of the Scillitan Martyrs; Passion of Perpetua and Felicity).
E	Early received tradition: Lactantius, Eusebius, Jerome, Augustine, Vincent of Lérins; evidence of reception and of otherwise lost reports, written 90–230 years after the subject.
L	Later tradition: Praedestinatus, the Gelasian Decree, medieval transmission, early-modern and confessional portraits.
M	Official ecclesial reception, limited to each act’s actual object (Catechism citations; Benedict XVI’s catechesis of 30 May 2007).
K	Named modern critical reconstruction (Barnes, Powell, Rankin, Tabbernee, and reviewers), used to its stated premises.
S	Source-grounded project synthesis, never attributed to a source.

A.5 Chronology

Dates below are claims with stated bases; “convention” marks customary dates this study does not assert as established.

Date	Event	Basis	Status
c. 155–170	Birth, presumably at or near Carthage	Modern estimate from career; no ancient evidence	Range only
180, 17 Jul	Scillitan martyrs tried at Carthage	Consular date in the Acts (N)	Secure
before c. 195	Conversion to Christianity	Inference from A (convert’s voice); no date, place, or circumstance recorded	Event secure, details unknown
c. 196/197	First datable works (<i>To the Nations</i> , <i>Apology</i>)	Internal allusions; standard scholarship (K)	Plausible
203, 7 Mar	Perpetua and Felicity die at Carthage	Passio tradition (N/E); Tertullian cites Perpetua (A)	Secure (year); day traditional
207/208	Third edition of <i>Against Marcion</i> in progress	“Fifteenth of the Emperor Severus” (A: 1.15)	Secure
c. 205–212	Open adherence to the New Prophecy; disciplinary works against the <i>psychici</i>	A (<i>On Fasting</i> , <i>On Monogamy</i> , <i>Against Praxeas</i> 1)	Secure as tendency; no dated “conversion”
211	Soldier’s refusal of the crown at an imperial donative	<i>The Chaplet</i> 1 (A); donative linked to 211 by scholarship (K)	Plausible

Date	Event	Basis	Status
212, after 14 Aug	<i>To Scapula</i>	Utica darkness (A: 3), identified with the eclipse of 14 Aug 212 (K)	Plausible–secure
after 212	Later disciplinary works; lost writings; old age	Jerome’s hearsay report (E)	Unresolved
c. 220/225	Death (customary date)	Convention splicing 212 with Jerome’s old age	Convention only
late 4th c.	Tertullianists active (Rome, Carthage)	Augustine (E, for his own time); Praedestinatus (L)	Secure for existence
c. 390s–420s	Last Tertullianists rejoin the Catholic Church of Carthage	Augustine, <i>On Heresies</i> 86 (E)	Secure

A.6 Method, limits, and negative results

Earliest controlled evidence governs; witnesses separated by centuries are never silently merged, and disagreements (birth and death dates, presbyterate, the schism question, the *On Modesty* bishop) are preserved. Geographic and linguistic limits: the study reads English translations of Latin and Greek sources; no manuscript, epigraphic, or archaeological research was undertaken, and no claim depends on unverified Latin wording except the famous tags expressly labeled as such. Bounded negative results: no ancient or modern liturgical commemoration, feast, cult, relic, grave, or canonization of Tertullian was located; no record of an excommunication or formal act of schism was located; no dedicated public commemoration of an anniversary of his death was located in searches conducted on 2026-07-24. These are bounded, correctable search results, not proofs of absence. Mutable online sources (Vatican website, Tertullian Project, CCEL, New Advent) were used as checked on 2026-07-24.

A.7 Rights and review state

Project prose is original; ancient quotations follow the public-domain Ante-Nicene Fathers translation (1885) and other public-domain nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century translations identified in the References. Copyrighted modern translations (e.g., of Augustine’s *On Heresies*) and modern scholarship are paraphrased or quoted only in brief attributed snippets within ordinary scholarly quotation; Vatican texts are paraphrased with citation. This publication has received internal editorial checking only: no independent specialist, theological, or ecclesiastical review, and no rights opinion, is claimed.

B References

All web sources were accessed and checked on 2026-07-24. Ancient-work citations in the text use conventional English titles with the chapter numbering of the translations listed here.

Primary sources: Tertullian

- Tertullian, works in English translation: *The Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vols. 3–4, ed. A. Roberts, J. Donaldson, A. C. Coxe (Buffalo: Christian Literature Publishing Co., 1885). Quotations follow the transcriptions at New Advent (<https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/>) and CCEL (<https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf03.html> and <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/schaff/anf04.html>). Works quoted: *Apology* 17, 37, 39, 50; *To Scapula* 2, 3, 5; *The Chaplet* 1, 3; *On Baptism* 1, 15, 17; *On Repentance* 4, 7, 9; *Of Patience* 1; *To His Wife* 1.1, 2.8; *Prescription Against Heretics* 7, 36; *Against Marcion* 1.1, 1.15; *Against Praxeas* 1, 2, 27; *On the Soul* 9, 55; *On the Resurrection of the Flesh* 8; *On the Veiling of Virgins* 1, 17; *On Exhortation to Chastity* 7; *On Monogamy* 1, 12; *On Fasting* 1; *On Modesty* 1; *On the Apparel of Women* 1.1; *The Shows* 30. The translation is public domain; underlying Latin is ancient and public domain.

Primary sources: other ancient witnesses

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- Lactantius, *Divine Institutes* 5.1, ANF vol. 7 translation at New Advent (<https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/07015.htm>).
- Jerome, *On Illustrious Men* 53, NPNF series 2 vol. 3 translation at New Advent (<https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/2708.htm>). “Give me the master” renders Jerome’s public-domain Latin *Da magistrum* as given in this translation.
- Augustine, *On Heresies* 86, paraphrased from the Latin text and the copyrighted translation of L. G. Müller (1956) as presented at the Tertullian Project (https://www.tertullian.org/tertullianistae/de_haeresibus.htm); no protected wording is reproduced.
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- Benedict XVI, General Audience of 30 May 2007 (catechesis on Tertullian), Vatican website (https://www.vatican.va/content/benedict-xvi/en/audiences/2007/documents/hf_ben-xvi_aud_20070530.html); paraphrased.
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Modern scholarship

- T. D. Barnes, *Tertullian: A Historical and Literary Study* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1971; reissued with postscript 1985). Consulted through the contemporary reviews reproduced at the Tertullian Project, principally W. H. C. Frend, *Classical Review* 24 (1974): 72–76 (https://www.tertullian.org/articles/frend_on_barnes.htm); Barnes’s conclusions are cited as reported there.
- D. Powell, “Tertullianists and Cataphrygians,” *Vigiliae Christianae* 29 (1975): 33–54; full text reproduced by permission of Brill at the Tertullian Project (https://www.tertullian.org/articles/powell_tertullianists.htm).
- D. Rankin, *Tertullian and the Church* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995); thesis paraphrased from the publisher’s book and chapter descriptions at Cambridge Core: <https://www.cambridge.org/core/books/tertullian-and-the-church/B47AD762216F1E525349DF6D639F6DBB>
- W. Tabbernee’s suggestion on the character of the *Tertullianistae* and the survey of positions at the Tertullian Project, “The Tertullianistae” (<https://www.tertullian.org/tertullianistae/tertullianistae.htm>).
- The Tertullian Project (ed. R. Pearse), orientation pages (<https://www.tertullian.org/>); used as a specialist finding aid, not as a critical edition.

C Generation Metadata

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